

LT 2010 Week 1 Hands-on Lab 1

Emmanuel Tigoue, Hands-on-Lab 1

My first prompt was "Write a text about the beauty of nature." ChatGPT gave me back a short, generic paragraph about trees, rivers, and the sky. It did not feel like any place in particular and I had a hard time picturing it.

So I rewrote it with more detail. The new prompt was "Write a text about the beauty of nature. Include imagery that appeals to all five senses. Highlight connections between animals, plants, and weather. Set it at dusk in late autumn."

This is what ChatGPT gave me back the second time:

"The fading amber sun strips the color from bare oak trees. Frost settles rapidly as the temperature drops. You feel the biting chill cutting through your clothes while tasting the sharp metallic cold of the incoming winter. The air smells of decaying pine and distant woodsmoke. Nearby, a whitetail deer crushes dry brittle leaves underfoot, rushing to eat the remaining acorns before the frozen ground locks away the food supply. The weather dictates the survival sequence."

You can pick out all five senses in there. Sight is the amber sun on the oak trees. Sound is the deer crushing brittle leaves. Smell is the pine and woodsmoke. Touch is the cold cutting through clothes. Taste is the metallic cold in the air. The last line also ties the deer, the plants, and the weather together as one survival picture, which is the connection part the prompt asked for.

1. How did the prompts you created influence the output generated by ChatGPT?

The detail in my prompt changed the detail in the answer. When I just said "beauty of nature," I got a basic paragraph that could have been about anywhere. Once I named the season, the time of day, the five senses, and the connections I wanted, ChatGPT got really specific. The deer, the frost, and the woodsmoke would not have shown up at all without those instructions in the prompt.

2. What did you learn about the importance of detail and specificity in prompt engineering? How did changing the details in your prompts affect the quality of the generated text?

I learned that a vague prompt gets you a vague answer. If I want something useful, I have to spell out what I want. Audience, time, place, and examples all matter. When I added the season and the senses, the second answer felt like a real place instead of a stock paragraph. This is something I plan to use for school and work, not just for creative writing assignments.